BHIMRAO RAMJI ‘BABASAHEB’ AMBEDKAR

1891–1956



A voracious reader, Ambedkar bought more than 2,000 books on a variety of subjects from second-hand bookstores in the US. Tragically, the ship carrying his books home in 1917 was sunk by a German torpedo strike.

The making of the scholar

Ambedkar was the fourteenth child of Ramji Sakpal, an officer in the British Indian army, and Bhimabai. The family belonged to the Mahar caste, which was considered ‘untouchable’ in the Hindu caste system. Discrimination was a near-constant in Ambedkar’s life from a very young age. At school, he was not allowed to sit near his classmates or touch the